

Teaching in Crisis: Burnout, Mental Health, and the Exodus from Education

The Issue

Teachers are leaving the profession at alarming rates—up to 55% within their first five years, with some districts experiencing annual turnover rates of 20-30%—due to overwhelming stress, technology overload, inadequate mental health support, and workplace conditions that prioritize standardized performance metrics over human well-being ("Teacher Burnout: ZipDo Education Reports 2026"; Ingersoll). This exodus represents not just a staffing crisis, but a fundamental breakdown in how society values and supports one of its most essential professions (Santoro; Goldstein). What was once viewed as a stable, respected calling has become widely regarded as an unsustainable career characterized by impossible demands, inadequate compensation, eroding autonomy, and complete disregard for educator wellness (Allegretto, "Teacher Pay Rises in 2023"; Darling-Hammond). The teachers who remain often operate in survival mode, compromising their physical health, mental well-being, family relationships, and passion for teaching just to make it through each day (Maslach and Leiter; Greenberg et al.). This is not merely a workforce problem—it's a moral crisis that threatens the foundation of public education and the futures of millions of children who deserve stable, supported, thriving educators (Chetty et al.; Ronfeldt et al.).

Why It Matters

The Relentless Nature of Teacher Stress

- Teachers face chronic stress from heavy workloads, behavior management, administrative demands, and rapid technology integration without proper training. The modern teacher's day extends far beyond classroom hours—arriving at school by 7:00 AM, staying until 5:00 or 6:00 PM, working weekends to catch up on grading and planning, and bringing work home most evenings is the norm, not the exception. The "summers off" myth ignores that many teachers work summer jobs, attend required professional development, or spend weeks preparing for the coming year—unpaid (Johnson et al.; "Every Minute Counts").
- The workweek regularly exceeds 50-60 hours, yet teachers are salaried and receive no overtime pay. When calculated hourly, many teachers earn less than \$20-25 per hour despite requiring bachelor's degrees (and often master's degrees) (Allegretto, "Teacher Pay Penalty Still Looms Large"; Allegretto and Mishel).
- Instructional time is only a fraction of the job. Teachers also plan differentiated lessons for diverse learners, grade mountains of assignments and assessments, respond to parent emails (which have increased exponentially with digital communication), attend endless meetings (staff meetings, department meetings, IEP meetings, 504 meetings, parent conferences, data meetings), complete extensive paperwork and documentation (attendance, discipline referrals, intervention logs, progress monitoring), supervise non-instructional duties (lunch, recess, hallways, bus duty, before/after school supervision), manage classroom logistics (organizing materials, maintaining bulletin boards, inventory), differentiate instruction for students with vastly different needs and abilities, and document everything for accountability purposes ("Every Minute Counts"; Kraft and Papay).
- Lesson planning alone can consume 5-10 hours per week for a single subject, multiplied across multiple subjects or grade levels. Creating engaging, standards-aligned lessons that accommodate diverse learners requires creativity, research, and time—time that doesn't exist ("Every Minute Counts").
- Grading is endless. A teacher with 150 students assigning one essay means 150 essays to grade—at 10 minutes each, that's 25 hours of grading for a single assignment. Teachers grade during lunch, after school, on weekends, late into the night ("Response: Making Grading Practices").

- Class sizes have grown while support staff has shrunk. Budget cuts have eliminated teaching assistants, aides, counselors, librarians, art and music teachers, and other support personnel. Teachers may be responsible for 30+ students (sometimes 35-40 in secondary classrooms) with a wide range of needs—from gifted learners requiring advanced material to those with IEPs (Individualized Education Programs) requiring specialized instruction and accommodations, English language learners needing language support, students experiencing trauma requiring social-emotional support, and those with behavioral challenges needing intensive intervention—often with minimal or no aide support ("Educators' Perspectives on Classroom Instruction"; Podolsky et al.).
- Inclusion without support is setup for failure. Teachers are expected to meet the needs of students with significant disabilities, behavioral disorders, or learning differences in general education classrooms—a worthy goal undermined by lack of training, planning time, co-teachers, or resources. Teachers want to serve all students but are set up to fail (Billingsley; "Special Educator Shortage").
- Behavior management has become increasingly difficult. Teachers report rising rates of classroom disruption, defiance, open disrespect, aggression, and even violence, often without adequate administrative backing, restorative justice resources, or training in trauma-informed approaches. They may face verbal abuse, threats, property damage, or physical altercations from students while being expected to maintain a positive, productive learning environment (Moon and McCluskey; McMahon et al.).
- Violence against teachers is underreported and minimized. Teachers have been punched, kicked, bitten, spat on, had objects thrown at them, been sexually harassed, and threatened—often with little consequence for students and sometimes blame directed at teachers for "not managing their classrooms" (McMahon et al.; Reddy et al.; Espelage et al.).
- Administrative support is inconsistent or absent. Teachers send students to the office for serious infractions only to have them returned immediately with no consequences, undermining classroom management and teacher authority. Some administrators prioritize avoiding conflict with parents over supporting teachers (Johnson et al.; Kraft and Papay).
- Trauma-informed practice without trauma-informed systems. Teachers are told to be trauma-informed and compassionate, to understand that "behavior is communication"—but are given no time, training, resources, or support to actually implement trauma-responsive practices. They're expected to individually absorb and address student trauma while managing 30+ other students (Figley; McMakin et al.).
- Parents can be hostile, demanding, or absent. Some parents email constantly with unrealistic demands, blame teachers for their children's struggles, threaten litigation, or undermine teachers' authority by contradicting them at home. Others are completely unreachable despite teachers' repeated attempts to communicate about serious concerns. Both extremes create stress (Titheradge et al.).
- Helicopter and lawnmower parenting have intensified. Parents who once trusted teachers now question every grade, assignment, and decision. Some demand constant communication and updates. Some complete assignments for their children or demand special treatment (Ouellette et al.).
- Standardized testing pressures consume instructional time and creativity. Teachers feel relentless pressure to "teach to the test" rather than engage students in meaningful, deep learning that fosters curiosity, critical thinking, and love of learning. Their job security, evaluations, and school funding may depend on test scores they cannot fully control, creating constant anxiety (Ravitch; Au).
- Testing narrows curriculum. Subjects not tested (art, music, social studies, science in some grades) are marginalized or eliminated. Within tested subjects, content and skills not on tests are abandoned. Education becomes about test preparation rather than authentic learning (Au; Ravitch).
- Data collection and analysis consume massive time with questionable benefit. Teachers administer frequent benchmark assessments, enter data into multiple systems, analyze results in meetings, and create data walls and graphs—time that could be spent actually teaching (Ravitch).

- Administrative demands multiply each year. New mandates, reporting requirements, professional development trainings (often irrelevant or poorly designed), curriculum changes, technology platforms, compliance documentation, and initiatives pile on without removing previous expectations. Every year adds more; nothing is ever taken away. Teachers feel like they're drowning in bureaucracy that serves administration and accountability rather than students (Ingersoll; Santoro).
- Paperwork is staggering. IEP documentation, 504 plans, behavior intervention plans, parent contact logs, lesson plans (sometimes requiring submission for approval), attendance, grades, progress reports, state reporting, intervention documentation—all while trying to actually teach (Billingsley; "Educators' Perspectives on Classroom Instruction").

Technology: Promise and Peril

- Rapid technology integration without proper training creates constant stress. Teachers are expected to master new learning management systems (Canvas, Google Classroom, Schoology), digital assessment tools, educational apps (often multiple apps for different subjects or purposes), video conferencing platforms (Zoom, Google Meet), interactive whiteboards or smartboards, student information systems, grade books, and communication platforms—often with minimal training (maybe a single professional development session or just an email saying "we're using this now") and while still teaching full-time with no reduction in other responsibilities ("Barriers to Teachers' Use of Technology"; Cuban; Reich).
- The pandemic accelerated technology demands exponentially. Overnight in March 2020, teachers had to redesign entire curricula for remote learning, learn new technologies under crisis conditions, troubleshoot technical issues for students and families (becoming IT support), record and upload video lessons, navigate privacy and equity concerns (students without devices or internet), manage asynchronous and synchronous instruction simultaneously, and maintain engagement through screens—all while managing their own fear and uncertainty about the virus, economic instability, and often while teaching their own children at home (McMakin et al.; Reich).
- The trauma of pandemic teaching is rarely acknowledged. Teachers worked harder than ever under impossible conditions, worried about their own health and their families' health, grieved losses, and tried to support traumatized students—then were blamed for "learning loss" and told they weren't doing enough (McMakin et al.).
- Technology rarely reduces workload—it often increases it. Digital communication means parents and students expect 24/7 availability—emails at 10 PM demanding immediate responses, messages on weekends, expectations that teachers are always accessible. Learning management systems require constant updating—posting assignments, resources, announcements, responding to messages. Grading platforms demand detailed input and comments. Each new tool promises efficiency but requires significant time to learn, set up, maintain, and troubleshoot when it inevitably malfunctions (Cuban; "Barriers to Teachers' Use of Technology").
- Teachers are expected to be tech support for students and sometimes parents, despite lacking IT training. When students can't log in, can't find assignments, can't submit work, or encounter technical problems—teachers are the first responders, problem-solving during class time or via email (Reich).
- Teachers lack technical support. When technology fails—and it often does—projectors won't connect, WiFi goes down, software crashes, devices malfunction—teachers are expected to troubleshoot while maintaining instruction, often without IT staff available or with long delays for support. Instructional time is lost; stress increases ("Barriers to Teachers' Use of Technology").
- Professional development on technology is often inadequate—one-shot workshops with no follow-up support, training on tools without pedagogical guidance on effective use, or mandatory trainings on tools teachers don't need or want (Cuban; Reich).
- Digital surveillance and monitoring of teachers has increased. Some districts use software to track teacher activity, monitor emails, evaluate productivity based on learning management system usage, or require cameras in classrooms.

This adds another layer of stress, erodes professional autonomy and trust, and creates a climate of suspicion rather than support (Santoro).

- Technology widens inequities. Teachers in well-resourced schools receive new devices, robust IT support, and professional development. Teachers in under-resourced schools inherit broken, outdated technology and are expected to make it work without support (Darling-Hammond; Cuban).

The Mental Health Support Gap

- Mental health resources for teachers are virtually nonexistent—no counseling services, limited sick days, and stigma around admitting struggles. Unlike many corporate workplaces that offer Employee Assistance Programs (EAPs) providing free confidential counseling, mental health days, wellness programs, or stress management resources, schools rarely provide such support for their staff—despite teaching being objectively more stressful than many corporate jobs (Greenberg et al.; Ouellette et al.).
- The irony is stark: Teachers are expected to support student mental health, recognize signs of distress, provide social-emotional learning, create safe spaces—while their own mental health is completely ignored (Greenberg et al.).
- Teachers often get fewer sick days than necessary (typically 7-10 per year, which must cover physical illness, mental health needs, family emergencies, and personal appointments) and face guilt or logistical nightmares when using them. Writing detailed substitute plans while sick—often more work than just teaching—means teachers come to work ill rather than deal with the burden of absence. Some districts require doctor's notes even for single-day absences, adding expense and hassle (Podolsky et al.).
- Substitutes are increasingly unavailable, meaning teachers' classes may be split among colleagues (adding to their burden), supervised by unqualified staff, or teachers are pressured to come to work sick because "there's no coverage" (Carver-Thomas and Darling-Hammond).
- Mental health days are rarely offered, and using sick days for mental health may require explaining personal struggles to administrators or providing medical documentation. The message: physical illness is legitimate; mental health struggles are not (Greenberg et al.).
- There's intense stigma around teacher mental health. Teachers are expected to be nurturing, stable, endlessly patient, self-sacrificing, and always "on." They're supposed to be role models of emotional regulation and resilience. Admitting anxiety, depression, burnout, or struggles can feel like professional suicide—teachers fear being seen as weak, ineffective, unable to handle the job, or unsuitable for working with children (Santoro; Maslach and Leiter).
- Colleagues may judge rather than support teachers who express struggles. Teaching culture sometimes valorizes martyrdom and suffering ("I worked through my own burnout; you should too"). Asking for help may be seen as incompetence (Hochschild).
- No one asks how teachers are doing. While teachers are trained to recognize student mental health struggles, administer SEL curricula, provide emotional support, and refer students for counseling, their own emotional needs are completely ignored. Administrators check on compliance and test scores, not teacher well-being. The expectation is to "leave personal problems at the door" and perform as if you have no inner life or struggles (Greenberg et al.; Ouellette et al.).
- Teachers absorb others' trauma without support. They witness and respond daily to student poverty, food insecurity, housing instability, abuse (physical, sexual, emotional), neglect, domestic violence, parental incarceration, parental substance abuse, homelessness, refugee trauma, community violence, mental health crises, and sometimes student death. This vicarious trauma—also called secondary traumatic stress—accumulates over years without processing, support, or acknowledgment. Teachers hold students' pain, provide stability and care, then go home carrying that weight with nowhere to put it down (Figley; McMakin et al.).

- Mandatory reporting responsibilities add emotional burden. Teachers are mandated reporters of child abuse and neglect—a critical responsibility that also means making heart-wrenching calls, navigating investigations, worrying about students' safety, and sometimes seeing students returned to unsafe situations. The emotional toll is enormous (Figley).
- Student suicides devastate teachers, who may blame themselves, question what they missed, grieve without adequate support, and face pressure to continue teaching immediately despite trauma (McMakin et al.; Greenberg et al.).
- Access to personal mental health care is limited. Teacher salaries (averaging \$60,000-\$65,000 nationally, less in many states and early-career stages) often make private therapy unaffordable at \$100-\$200+ per session. School district insurance may have high deductibles (\$2,000-\$5,000), limited mental health coverage (capping sessions at 6-12 per year), or narrow networks making it difficult to find providers. Finding therapists who understand the unique, intense demands of teaching is difficult—therapy may feel like one more place to explain and justify ("Educator Pay"; Allegretto, "Teacher Pay Penalty Still Looms Large").
- Therapy appointments conflict with work hours. Teachers can't leave school for appointments during the day (no coverage, using precious sick time), so must find evening or weekend appointments—which are hard to get and interfere with personal time (Greenberg et al.).
- Some teachers fear seeking help could affect their employment if administrators or HR learn of mental health treatment, despite legal protections (Santoro).

Burnout and Compassion Fatigue: The Invisible Epidemic

- Burnout and compassion fatigue go unaddressed, leading to physical and emotional exhaustion. Teacher burnout—recognized by the WHO as an occupational phenomenon—is characterized by three dimensions: emotional exhaustion (feeling drained, depleted, unable to give anymore), depersonalization or cynicism (negative, detached attitudes toward students, colleagues, or work), and reduced sense of personal accomplishment (feeling ineffective, that nothing you do matters) (Maslach et al., "Job Burnout"; Maslach and Leiter).
- Physical symptoms are pervasive: chronic fatigue (waking up exhausted regardless of sleep), insomnia (unable to fall asleep due to racing thoughts about work, or waking at 3 AM with anxiety), frequent headaches or migraines, digestive issues (IBS, nausea, stomach pain), weakened immune systems (getting every illness students bring to class), unexplained aches and pains, weight changes (stress eating or loss of appetite), high blood pressure, and stress-related illnesses. Teachers often work through sickness because taking time off creates more work (sub plans, catching up, students falling behind) and guilt (Titheradge et al.; Greenberg et al.).
- Emotional and psychological symptoms include: persistent anxiety (generalized worry, panic attacks, specific fears about going to work), depression (hopelessness, loss of interest in activities once enjoyed, persistent sadness), irritability and mood swings (snapping at family, students, or colleagues), feeling numb or emotionally detached (unable to feel joy or connection), loss of enthusiasm for teaching (the passion that brought them to the profession has died), difficulty concentrating and making decisions (brain fog from chronic stress), sense of hopelessness and helplessness (feeling trapped with no way out), and intrusive thoughts about work (unable to mentally disengage even at home) (Maslach et al., "Job Burnout"; Skaalvik and Skaalvik).
- Compassion fatigue—also called secondary traumatic stress—specifically depletes teachers' ability to empathize. After years of giving emotionally to students, hearing their trauma, responding to their needs, and caring deeply about their well-being, some teachers find themselves emotionally spent, unable to connect with students' needs the way they once did, feeling nothing when students share struggles. This leads to profound guilt ("I'm supposed to care, but I feel nothing"), shame, and further distress. Teachers may feel they've become the cynical, burned-out teachers they never wanted to be (Figley; McMakin et al.).
- The cost of caring is rarely acknowledged. Caring professions—teaching, nursing, social work—demand emotional labor that depletes practitioners, yet this is treated as part of the job rather than occupational hazard requiring support

(Hochschild; Isenbarger and Zembylas).

- Teachers sacrifice personal relationships and self-care. The job consumes time and energy that should go to spouses/partners (leading to relationship strain and sometimes divorce), children (teachers' own kids may feel neglected), friendships (cancelled plans, no energy for socializing), hobbies and interests (no time or mental space for things they enjoy), exercise (too exhausted after work), healthy eating (grabbing fast food or eating lunch in 15 minutes while working), and adequate rest. Teachers report guilt when not working, feeling they should always be doing more for their students—yet no amount is ever enough (Maslach and Leiter; Santoro).
- Sleep deprivation is chronic. Teachers stay up late grading and planning, wake up early for school, and often can't sleep due to stress—creating sleep debt that affects every aspect of health and functioning (Titheradge et al.).
- Weekends and breaks don't provide recovery. Teachers spend weekends catching up on work, and school breaks preparing for the next term or working second jobs. There's no true rest (Maslach and Leiter).
- Substance use as coping mechanism. Some teachers turn to alcohol to unwind after stressful days, prescription medications (anxiety meds, sleep aids) to manage symptoms, or other substances—which can develop into dependency and create additional problems. Teacher substance use is rarely discussed but is a predictable outcome of untreated chronic stress (Greenberg et al.).
- Eating disorders or disordered eating can develop from stress, loss of control (food becomes something controllable), or neglecting meals due to time constraints (Greenberg et al.).
- Suicidal ideation is not uncommon among severely burned-out teachers, though rarely discussed. The combination of chronic stress, feeling trapped (financial obligations, benefits, lack of other job options), isolation, shame, and hopelessness creates conditions where some teachers think about ending their lives. Some have attempted or completed suicide, their deaths sometimes attributed to "personal issues" rather than recognized as occupational casualties. The teaching profession's failure to address mental health makes it complicit in these tragedies (Maslach et al., "Job Burnout"; Greenberg et al.).

The Exodus: Who's Leaving and Why

- High turnover disrupts student learning and disproportionately affects under-resourced schools. Annual turnover rates of 15-20% nationally (higher in some districts and high-poverty schools where rates can exceed 30%) mean students, especially those in high-poverty schools serving students of color, may experience a revolving door of teachers, preventing the stable, consistent relationships crucial for learning, development, and emotional security. Students in schools that can least afford disruption experience the most (Ronfeldt et al.; Simon and Johnson).
- Turnover costs districts billions annually in recruiting, hiring, and training—money that could improve teacher working conditions and prevent turnover (Carver-Thomas and Darling-Hammond).
- Early-career teachers leave in droves. The first five years are critical for developing teaching expertise, but inadequate mentoring (new teachers assigned mentors who are overwhelmed themselves or mentoring programs that are token rather than substantive), overwhelming demands (being assigned the most challenging classes or largest class sizes because they're new), isolation (no time for collaboration or observation), lack of support (left to figure it out alone), and reality shock (the gap between idealistic teacher preparation and the harsh realities of under-resourced, high-pressure schools) push many out before they've fully developed their skills. Nearly half of new teachers leave before becoming truly effective—a massive loss of potential and investment (Ingersoll; Borman and Dowling).
- Teacher preparation programs often fail to prepare teachers for the realities they'll face, focusing on idealized pedagogy without addressing classroom management, working with trauma-affected students, navigating difficult parents, or surviving in under-resourced schools (Darling-Hammond; Santoro).

- Early-career teachers are set up to fail: given the hardest assignments, most challenging students, largest class sizes, worst classrooms, and minimal support—then blamed when they struggle (Podolsky et al.; Kraft and Papay).
- Veteran teachers are retiring early or leaving mid-career. Experienced educators who once loved teaching—who stayed for decades despite low pay because they found the work meaningful—report the job has become unrecognizable: more about compliance than connection, data than discovery, test scores than relationships, surveillance than trust. They're leaving not because they don't care, but because they can no longer do the job they were trained and called to do (Santoro).
- The loss of veteran teachers is catastrophic. These educators hold institutional memory, curriculum expertise, mentorship capacity, community relationships, and refined pedagogical skills built over decades. When they leave, that knowledge disappears (Borman and Dowling; Ronfeldt et al.).
- Mid-career teachers face particular crisis: They've invested 10-20 years, but realize they can't sustain another 15-25. They're young enough to change careers but old enough to have financial obligations (mortgages, children, retirement concerns) that make leaving terrifying. Many feel trapped (Santoro).
- Teachers of color leave at higher rates (15-20% higher than white teachers) due to additional stressors including: isolation in predominantly white schools where they may be the only teacher of color in their building, microaggressions from colleagues ("You're so articulate!" "Can you speak for all Black people?"), microaggressions and racism from white parents who question their qualifications or request their children be moved to white teachers' classes, lack of culturally responsive curriculum support and being expected to educate white colleagues about racism, being overburdened with "diversity work"—asked to serve on every equity committee, counsel every student of color, represent their race at events—without compensation or reduced teaching load, and hostile school cultures that don't value their perspectives or address racism (Achinstein et al.; Ingersoll and May; "Disrespect, Low Pay, Lack of Support").
- The teaching force is 80% white while student populations are majority students of color—a mismatch that matters. Students benefit from teachers who share their racial/ethnic identities, yet these teachers are driven out at higher rates ("U.S. Public School Teachers Much Less Racially Diverse"; Gershenson et al.; "America Needs More Teachers of Color").
- Indigenous teachers are almost nonexistent outside of tribal schools, and Indigenous students—already facing educational disparities—rarely see themselves reflected in their teachers (Achinstein et al.).
- Special education teachers face particularly high burnout (turnover rates exceeding 25% in some areas) due to: enormous caseloads (15-30+ students with complex, individualized needs), extensive paperwork (IEPs that can run 20-50 pages, each requiring multiple hours to write and update, plus progress monitoring, behavior tracking, and parent communication), complex legal requirements (IDEA compliance, due process, manifestation determinations) creating constant fear of litigation, challenging behaviors (students with emotional/behavioral disorders, aggression, self-injury) without adequate training or support, and often working with the most vulnerable students—those with significant disabilities, trauma, poverty—while being the most under-resourced. Special education is treated as the "dumping ground" for problems, with teachers expected to work miracles without support ("Special Educator Shortage"; Billingsley; Brunsting et al.).
- Special education teachers report feeling like they're failing students because caseloads make individualized attention impossible, but leaving means students have no one (Billingsley; Brunsting et al.).
- Teachers leave for jobs that pay better, respect professional judgment, and offer work-life balance. Many transition to: corporate training (earning \$70,000-\$100,000+ with better hours and respect), educational technology companies (using their expertise while escaping classroom stress), curriculum development, instructional coaching, tutoring, or leaving education entirely for careers like project management, sales, HR, or grad school in other fields—taking their expertise, institutional knowledge, and investment (often master's degrees and years of experience) with them. Society loses their talent and training (Allegretto, "Teacher Pay Penalty Still Looms Large"; Podolsky et al.).

- The teacher-to-corporate-trainer pipeline is well-worn. Companies value ex-teachers' skills; teachers are relieved to be valued, paid fairly, and treated as professionals (Allegretto and Mishel).
- Some teachers leave for mental health survival. They don't have another job lined up; they simply cannot continue without risking their lives. These teachers describe leaving as "escaping" or "saving myself" (Santoro; Maslach and Leiter).

Systemic Issues: Why the Profession Is Seen as Unsustainable

- The profession is seen as unsustainable, deterring new teachers from entering the field. College students—who once might have considered teaching—hear from teacher friends, family members, and the media that the job is "not worth it," that it's thankless, overwhelming, and underpaid. Enrollment in teacher preparation programs has declined 30-35% nationally over the past decade, creating a pipeline crisis. Who can blame them? Rational people don't choose careers with terrible working conditions, low pay, and high stress (Nietzel; Podolsky et al.).
- Student teaching requirements create barriers. Prospective teachers must work full-time unpaid for 10-16 weeks (often longer), making teaching inaccessible to those without financial support. Many can't afford to student teach, especially those from the working-class and communities of color whose representation is desperately needed (Darling-Hammond; Ingersoll and May).
- Low pay relative to education level and workload. Teachers often need master's degrees (required for licensure advancement in many states) but earn far less than other professionals with similar education—20-30% less than peers in other fields. Starting salaries are often \$35,000-\$45,000 (lower in some states), and even experienced teachers may cap out at \$60,000-\$70,000 after 20+ years. Many work second jobs (tutoring, retail, driving for ride-share, coaching, summer jobs) to make ends meet. Some qualify for public assistance despite having advanced degrees and working 50-60 hour weeks (Allegretto, "Teacher Pay Penalty Still Looms Large"; Allegretto and Mishel; "Educator Pay").
- The salary schedule is absurd: Teachers earn roughly the same whether they teach 15 students or 35, whether they're effective or ineffective, whether they work 40 hours or 70. There's no incentive structure recognizing excellence or extra effort (Podolsky et al.).
- Pay has stagnated or declined in real terms when adjusted for inflation, despite increasing demands and credential requirements (Allegretto, "Teacher Pay Rises in 2023").
- Lack of professional autonomy and respect. Teachers are increasingly micromanaged through scripted curricula (told exactly what to say and do each minute of each lesson, removing professional judgment), rigid pacing guides (that ignore whether students are actually learning), mandated instructional models, and surveillance (administrators conducting frequent observations, walk-throughs, or requiring detailed lesson plan submissions), despite being trained professionals with degrees, certifications, and expertise. Politicians and policymakers with no classroom experience (or who taught briefly decades ago) make decisions about education—curriculum, testing, evaluation, funding—often against educators' recommendations (Ravitch; Santoro).
- Teachers are treated as interchangeable widgets delivering prescribed content rather than skilled professionals making complex, moment-to-moment decisions based on student needs (Santoro; Goldstein).
- Curriculum adoption happens without teacher input, with districts purchasing expensive programs that teachers find ineffective or inappropriate, then mandating "fidelity" to the program regardless of student needs (Ravitch).
- Evaluation systems are punitive rather than supportive, focused on compliance and gotcha observations rather than growth and coaching (Au; Kraft and Papay).
- Blame culture is pervasive. Teachers are blamed for student failure, achievement gaps, and social problems (poverty, inequality, racism, family instability), while systemic issues like chronic underfunding, inequitable resource distribution, poverty, housing insecurity, food insecurity, lack of healthcare, trauma, and structural racism are ignored. When

students struggle, teachers are blamed for "not doing enough" or "making excuses." Public discourse—from politicians, media, and even some community members—often vilifies teachers (calling them lazy, entitled, or incompetent), questions their motivation ("those who can't do, teach"), or accuses them of not caring, rather than celebrating and supporting them (Goldstein; Darling-Hammond).

- Teachers are scapegoated for societal failures. Schools are expected to solve poverty, inequality, mental health crises, and social problems—without resources—then blamed when they can't (Ravitch; Darling-Hammond).
- "Failing schools" rhetoric blames educators while ignoring that these schools serve students facing the most significant challenges with the fewest resources (Simon and Johnson; Darling-Hammond).
- No clear career advancement without leaving the classroom. Teaching has a flat career structure—a first-year teacher and a 30-year veteran do essentially the same job. The only way to earn significantly more money, gain leadership opportunities, or advance is to become an administrator (assistant principal, principal, district office)—which means leaving teaching behind, the work they love and trained for. Master teachers who are exceptional in the classroom have few options for growth, leadership, increased responsibility, or recognition while remaining in the classroom. There's no pathway to earn \$90,000-\$100,000 as a classroom teacher in most districts, regardless of excellence (Ingersoll; Podolsky et al.).
- Teacher leadership opportunities are add-ons (department chair, team lead, mentor teacher) that come with small stipends (\$1,000-\$3,000 annually) and significant additional work—not meaningful career pathways ("Educator Pay").
- The "teacher as martyr" narrative is toxic. Society expects teachers to work for love of children, not money—to buy classroom supplies with their own funds (teachers spend an average of \$500-\$750 of personal money annually on supplies, decorations, snacks for hungry students, books), work unpaid overtime (the hours beyond contract time are just "part of being a good teacher"), sacrifice personal well-being and family time, and accept low pay because the work is "rewarding." This exploitation is romanticized in movies and cultural narratives ("inspiring teacher saves struggling students through sheer dedication") rather than challenged as worker exploitation. The message: teachers should be grateful for the opportunity to serve and shouldn't expect fair compensation or reasonable conditions (Hochschild; Isenbarger and Zembylas; Goldstein).
- The martyr narrative guilt-trips teachers who set boundaries, leave on time, or decline extra duties—framed as "not caring about kids" (Santoro).
- School violence and safety concerns. Teachers worry about school shootings (the U.S. has experienced hundreds of school shootings), practice lockdown drills that traumatize them and students (huddling silently in dark corners practicing what to do if a shooter enters the building), face threats from students or community members, and some experience physical violence—yet receive inadequate protection, support, or consequences for perpetrators. Some teachers have been killed in school shootings; all teachers live with this fear (McMahon et al.; Moon and McCluskey; Reddy et al.).
- Active shooter drills are traumatizing and create constant ambient fear, yet are treated as routine rather than as the emergency preparedness for violence that they are (Espelage et al.; Reddy et al.).
- School resource officers (police in schools) create other problems, often criminalizing student behavior, particularly affecting students of color and students with disabilities, without making teachers feel safer (Darling-Hammond).

Impact on Students and Educational Quality

- Teacher well-being directly impacts classroom climate, student outcomes, and education quality. Research consistently shows that teacher stress and burnout correlate with lower student achievement, decreased student engagement, increased behavioral problems in classrooms, and worse relationships between teachers and students. Stressed, burned-

out teachers cannot provide the high-quality instruction, emotional support, and positive relationships that drive student success (Chetty et al.; "How Teachers' Burnout Shapes Students' Behavioural Engagement"; Ronfeldt et al.).

- Burned-out teachers have less patience, creativity, emotional availability, and energy for students. They may resort to more controlling, rigid teaching methods (worksheets, lectures, compliance-focused management), provide less differentiation and individualization, respond less responsively to individual student needs, offer fewer creative enrichment activities, and struggle to build the warm, supportive relationships that students—especially those facing adversity—desperately need (Skaalvik and Skaalvik; "How Teachers' Burnout Shapes Students' Behavioural Engagement").
- Students can tell when teachers are burned out. They sense the exhaustion, disconnection, and going-through-the-motions teaching. The classroom climate suffers; students feel it's just a job to the teacher, not a calling (Hamre and Pianta).
- High teacher turnover harms students academically and emotionally. Students lose continuity of instruction (mid-year departures are particularly disruptive), lose relationships with teachers they trusted and connected with, lose the benefits of experienced teachers (new teachers are less effective in their first years), and experience instability that's particularly harmful for students already facing trauma and instability in their lives. They may develop trust issues ("Adults always leave"), disengagement ("Why bother connecting if they'll just leave?"), or behavioral problems in response to transitions (Ronfeldt et al.; Hamre and Pianta).
- Turnover concentrates in schools serving the most vulnerable students, compounding inequity. High-poverty schools, schools serving majority students of color, rural schools, and schools in challenging urban environments experience the highest turnover, meaning students who most need stable, experienced teachers are least likely to have them (Simon and Johnson; Ingersoll; Carver-Thomas and Darling-Hammond).
- The teaching profession loses diversity. When teachers of color, LGBTQ+ teachers, teachers from working-class backgrounds, and other marginalized educators burn out and leave, students lose: role models who look like them, adults who understand their cultural backgrounds and experiences, culturally responsive teaching that affirms their identities, and diverse perspectives in curriculum and pedagogy. This perpetuates educational inequity and cultural mismatch between teachers and students (Achinstein et al.; Gershenson et al.; "U.S. Public School Teachers Much Less Racially Diverse").
- Substitute teacher shortages mean students lose instructional time when teachers are absent (for illness, professional development, or personal reasons). Classes may be: split among colleagues (who then have 40+ students—watching a movie or doing busywork because actual teaching is impossible), supervised by unqualified adults (paraprofessionals, office staff, or even strangers with no teaching training or subject knowledge), or cancelled entirely with students sent to study hall or sent home. Each day without qualified instruction is lost learning (Carver-Thomas and Darling-Hammond).
- Long-term substitutes are often unqualified in the subject, unable to maintain curriculum continuity, or ineffective, meaning students lose weeks or months of quality instruction when teachers resign mid-year (Ronfeldt et al.).
- Teachers are pressured to come to work sick because "there's no coverage," exposing students and colleagues to illness and perpetuating presenteeism culture (Podolsky et al.).
- Institutional knowledge disappears. When experienced teachers leave, schools lose: deep curriculum expertise built over years of teaching and refining, student relationship history (knowing siblings, families, community dynamics), mentorship for new teachers (who now have no one to learn from), collective wisdom about what works (effective strategies, local context, institutional culture), and historical perspective on initiatives and reforms (Borman and Dowling; Ingersoll).
- Schools in perpetual churn never build coherence, constantly restarting with new teachers implementing new ideas without learning from past efforts (Ronfeldt et al.).

- Innovation and joy disappear from classrooms. Burned-out teachers focus on survival—getting through the day, maintaining control, meeting minimum requirements—rather than creative, engaging, student-centered teaching that inspires curiosity and love of learning. Field trips stop, projects are abandoned for worksheets, inquiry is replaced with direct instruction, joy is replaced with compliance. Students receive instruction, but not education (Santoro; Skaalvik and Skaalvik).
- The classroom becomes transactional rather than transformational: complete the assignment, get the grade, move on—rather than deep engagement, exploration, and growth (Santoro).
- Students' own mental health suffers. Teacher stress affects student stress. Harsh, controlling teaching creates anxiety. The absence of supportive relationships leaves students without crucial adults they need (Hamre and Pianta; "How Teachers' Burnout Shapes Students' Behavioural Engagement").

Intersecting Vulnerabilities

- Teachers with their own mental health conditions (anxiety disorders, depression, ADHD, PTSD, bipolar disorder, OCD) face additional challenges managing symptoms while meeting overwhelming job demands, often without workplace accommodations (which require disclosure that carries stigma and risk). The job's structure—constant stimulation, rapid decision-making, multitasking, sensory overload—is particularly challenging for neurodivergent teachers (Ouellette et al.; Greenberg et al.).
- Teachers hide diagnoses fearing they'll be seen as unfit for working with children or unable to handle the job, going unmedicated or untreated to avoid disclosure (Santoro).
- Teachers who are parents face impossible work-life conflicts, especially mothers who shoulder disproportionate caregiving responsibilities due to gendered expectations. They leave school exhausted, then begin their "second shift" at home—cooking, childcare, homework help, household management. The pandemic laid bare the impossibility of teaching other people's children remotely while simultaneously supervising and teaching one's own children—yet this impossible situation was expected. Teacher-mothers report guilt both ways: feeling they're failing their students and failing their own children (Hochschild; Isenbarger and Zembylas).
- Teacher-parents may miss their own children's school events, evenings, and bedtimes due to work demands, creating grief and guilt (Maslach and Leiter).
- Childcare costs consume significant portions of teacher salaries, making the math of continuing teaching not make sense for some, particularly in expensive urban areas ("Daycare Teacher Salary in US 2025"; "Educator Pay").
- LGBTQ+ teachers in unsupportive or hostile environments face additional stress from: hiding their identities (removing photos, censoring personal stories, being misgendered, not bringing partners to school events) to avoid discrimination, navigating discriminatory policies ("Don't Say Gay" laws, bathroom restrictions, curriculum censorship), dealing with community backlash (parents demanding they be fired, students making homophobic/transphobic comments without consequence), and lack of institutional support or protection from harassment. This constant vigilance and concealment is exhausting and psychologically harmful (Santoro).
- LGBTQ+ teachers are leaving in response to hostile political climates and legislation targeting them and their students (Goldstein).
- Teachers in rural areas often face: professional isolation (being the only teacher of their grade/subject, no one to collaborate with), limited resources (no access to professional development, curriculum materials, or technology), intense community scrutiny (everyone knows everyone; lack of privacy), conservative cultures that may be hostile to progressive pedagogy or LGBTQ+ identities, and difficulty accessing mental health care (no providers, long distances, lack of anonymity) (Johnson et al.; Simon and Johnson).

- Rural teachers may be unable to leave due to housing costs, family ties, or lack of other opportunities in the area—feeling trapped (Podolsky et al.).
- Early childhood and elementary teachers are undervalued compared to secondary teachers (earning less in some systems, viewed as "babysitters" rather than educators), despite the critical importance of early education for brain development and foundational skills, and the enormous emotional labor of working with young children (who need constant supervision, physical care, social-emotional support, and regulation) ("Daycare Teacher Salary in US 2025"; Isenbarger and Zembylas).
- Early childhood educators are the lowest paid in education, with many preschool teachers earning poverty wages without benefits, despite needing credentials ("Daycare Teacher Salary in US 2025").
- Teachers in tested grades and subjects (especially 3rd-5th grade ELA and math, high school core subjects) face the highest pressure and stress, while encore teachers (art, music, PE, world language) face elimination and marginalization despite providing essential experiences (Au; Ravitch).

What Teachers Need (But Aren't Getting)

Working Conditions:

- Reasonable workloads and class sizes that allow for meaningful instruction, individualized attention, and authentic relationships—maximum 20 students in elementary, 25 in secondary (Johnson et al.; Podolsky et al.)
- Adequate planning time during the workday—not just one 45-minute "prep period" for teaching 5+ classes or all subjects, but multiple hours daily for planning, grading, collaboration, and professional learning ("Every Minute Counts")
- Reduced non-instructional duties (lunch/recess supervision, hallway monitoring, bus duty) by hiring support staff for these roles (Podolsky et al.)
- Manageable expectations—saying no to new initiatives or requirements without adding time/resources (Ingersoll; Santoro)

Compensation:

- Competitive salaries that reflect education level (bachelor's and master's degrees), professional responsibilities, and societal importance—starting at \$60,000+ and reaching \$100,000+ for experienced teachers (Allegretto and Mishel; "Educator Pay")
- Geographic cost-of-living adjustments so teachers can afford to live in the communities they serve (Allegretto, "Teacher Pay Rises in 2023")
- Elimination of expectation that teachers fund classrooms from personal money (Goldstein)
- Stipends or reduced loads for extra responsibilities (mentoring, leadership, curriculum development) (Podolsky et al.)

Mental Health and Well-Being:

- Comprehensive mental health support: Free confidential counseling through EAPs, peer support groups facilitated by mental health professionals, trauma processing support after critical incidents, and regular check-ins on teacher well-being (Greenberg et al.; Figley)
- Mental health days separate from sick leave—5-10 per year minimum (Greenberg et al.)
- Adequate sick leave (15+ days annually) without requiring doctor's notes or justification (Podolsky et al.)
- Manageable substitute system so teachers can actually use leave without guilt (Carver-Thomas and Darling-Hammond)

Professional Support:

- Professional autonomy and trust to make pedagogical decisions based on expertise and student needs (Ravitch; Santoro)
- Quality professional development that is relevant, job-embedded, ongoing, and optional—not one-shot compliance trainings (Kraft and Papay)
- Technology training and ongoing support before and after new tools are mandated—instructional coaches and IT support (Cuban; Reich)
- Strong mentoring programs pairing new teachers with reduced-load mentors who have time for meaningful support (Ingersoll; Borman and Dowling)
- Collaboration time built into the schedule for teachers to plan together, observe each other, and share expertise (Johnson et al.; Kraft and Papay)

Administrative and Systemic:

- Administrative backing on discipline (consequences for student behavior, not sending students immediately back), parent conflicts (supporting teachers' professional judgment), and safety (protecting teachers from violence) (Moon and McCluskey; Reddy et al.)
- Reduced bureaucracy—eliminate redundant paperwork, streamline documentation, prioritize teaching over data entry (Ingersoll; Santoro)
- Career ladders that allow teachers to grow, lead, take on new challenges, and earn significantly more while staying in the classroom—pathways to \$90,000-\$120,000 as master/lead teachers (Podolsky et al.; "Educator Pay")
- Respect and appreciation from administrators, policymakers, parents, and society—tangible recognition of contributions, not just lip service (Goldstein; Darling-Hammond)

Safety and Environment:

- Safe working conditions including physical safety (protection from violence, adequate security, crisis response plans), protection from harassment (from students, parents, or colleagues), and healthy work environments (functioning HVAC, clean facilities, adequate space and resources) (McMahon et al.; Reddy et al.; Espelage et al.)
- Trauma-informed school systems—not just expecting individual teachers to be trauma-informed, but implementing schoolwide practices, staffing (counselors, social workers, behavior specialists), and resources to support students' trauma without burning out teachers (Figley; McMakin et al.)
- **Accountability and Policy:**
- Realistic accountability systems that measure growth and context (student progress, not just scores), account for factors beyond teacher control (poverty, resources, student mobility), and focus on continuous improvement rather than punishment (Au; Ravitch)
- Teacher voice in policy—including teachers in decisions about curriculum, evaluation, testing, and working conditions (Santoro; Darling-Hammond)
- Union protections allowing collective bargaining for working conditions, due process, and grievance procedures (Goldstein)

The Bottom Line

Teaching has become an unsustainable profession by design, not by accident (Santoro; Ingersoll). The exodus of educators—early-career teachers fleeing before they fully develop their skills (Borman and Dowling), veteran teachers retiring early or leaving mid-career despite decades of investment (Santoro), teachers of color driven out at higher rates by additional stressors and hostile environments (Achinstein et al.; Ingersoll and May)—represents not just a workforce crisis but a societal moral failure (Darling-Hammond; Goldstein). Teachers are bleeding out—physically, emotionally, and professionally—while being told to do more with less, blamed for problems they didn't create and cannot solve alone (Ravitch), surveilled and micromanaged despite being credentialed professionals (Santoro; Au), and compensated inadequately for work that demands their full humanity (Allegretto and Mishel; Allegretto, "Teacher Pay Penalty Still Looms Large"). The mental health of teachers is not a luxury, a personal problem, or an individual weakness to overcome through yoga and self-care apps—it is an urgent systemic crisis that affects millions of students who deserve stable, supported, thriving educators capable of providing the intellectual challenge, emotional support, and transformative relationships that drive learning and development (Greenberg et al.; Maslach et al., "Job Burnout"; Chetty et al.). Without meaningful investment in teacher well-being (Greenberg et al.; Figley), reasonable and humane working conditions (Johnson et al.; Kraft and Papay), competitive compensation that allows educators to support themselves and their families with dignity (Allegretto and Mishel; Podolsky et al.), and profound cultural change that values educators as the skilled, essential professionals they are (Goldstein; Darling-Hammond), the exodus will continue and accelerate—and an entire generation of students, particularly those already facing the greatest challenges and inequities (Simon and Johnson; Ronfeldt et al.), will pay the price in lost learning, lost relationships, lost opportunity, and lost potential. Teachers cannot pour from empty cups, and right now, those cups are bone dry, shattered on the floor of under-resourced classrooms where educators work miracles daily despite being set up to fail (Maslach and Leiter; Skaalvik and Skaalvik). The teaching crisis is a societal choice—we have chosen to undervalue, undersupport, and exploit the people we entrust with our children's futures—and it will require societal commitment and investment to fix (Darling-Hammond; Goldstein; Ravitch). Teachers are not asking for charity or special treatment; they are demanding what every worker deserves: fair pay, reasonable conditions, respect, and the support necessary to do their jobs well without sacrificing their health, families, and lives (Hochschild; Isenbarger and Zembylas; Santoro). Until we provide that, we will continue losing talented, dedicated educators—and the students, communities, and society we claim to value will be immeasurably poorer for it (Ingersoll; Ronfeldt et al.; Chetty et al.).

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